

Finding joy in little things



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This past month was a bit of an odd one for me. I went back to gaming on a PC, as I used to before my gaming console days. I started playing Counter Strike Global Offensive on the PC. Something that I wouldn't have considered even a few months ago, fixated as I have been on my PS4 games library since Dec 2014. All the Digit folk here in the Mumbai office at least are die-hard PC gamers and it was fun to partake in their gaming sessions after a long, long time. I was no stranger to Counter Strike, having played it in my college days at cyber cafes and briefly when I had newly joined Digit back in 2011. Getting back to the game in full swing last month, I had plenty of fun battling the likes of Siddharth, Abhijit, Mithun and Nikhil, whenever we played locally, or took on complete strangers in the heat of multiplayer matches. Even a few Digit readers who follow me on Steam noticed my renewed activity and played a few matches with me. All of a sudden, gaming became a whole lot of fun – an aspect that was missing from my life in general over the past few months.

At home, observing my two-year-old daughter's increasing appetite for all things tech has given me a sense of learning, far more than just pride and joy. Little things like discovering letters from the English alphabet printed in her pre-kindergarten books on our home desktop PC's keyboard and my laptop made her jaw drop and eyes light up in awe. Suddenly from merely memorizing and visualizing the letters on printed pages or plastic blocks, she could now press down little keys and have the letters magically appear in front of her screen was a big revelation, something that gave her new ideas as to what more she can do with her A, B and Cs.

Last month, I also happened to reconnect with a whole string of relatives whom I'd not met in decades. Hailing from our native village, they were relatively less accustomed to technological marvels that have become a daily part of our lives here in the city. Things like ordering diapers from Amazon, booking a Meru cab for an urgent journey in the middle of the night,

and booking tickets to the nearest cinema hall – all from the comfort of your phone was nothing short of magical to their rustic way of life. Heck, one of my elder relatives, who had never before seen a touchscreen smartphone, took to it like a fish to water. He stayed with us for a little over a week, and within that time he had managed to not only master more than just the basics of how to operate an Android smartphone but he even went on to purchase a brand new one he liked (online, of course) to use as his primary phone back in the village. His reactions and sense of wonder was similar to my daughter's when she figured out typing letters.

The biggest challenge in doing something that we like over and over again is to not let it devolve into a chore. The minute this happens, it instantly starts diminishing your sense of fun and excitement levels. We shouldn't let technology and our appreciation of the role it plays in our lives reduce to a mundane occurrence.

That's what I was experiencing with my gaming sessions, especially – and no, I'm not blaming it all on deteriorating levels of games in general. I was as much to blame. For a number of reasons, treating every game as a fun activity with no overheads (like a timely review or analysis for SKOAR) was becoming a tad difficult. However, I only had to shift platforms to reinvigorate the once steady flame of juvenile excitement and unbridled joy every time I started a new gaming session on my PC. It was an awesome feeling. I can't wait to sit through my first whole session of VR gaming, which I expect it to happen sometime within this year itself. That will really send my head into a tizzy!

How do you find joy in little things and how does technology help you in your quest? Drop me a line. 